Yin-Yang: **PARADOXICAL TRUTHS**

Manage your HR paradoxes for organisational success.

Recently, I had posted two questions on Facebook for HR practitioners: 1) What are the paradoxical roles of HRM; and 2) How can we alter the negative perception of HR practitioners, not only from employees but also from Chief Executive Officers? How can we convince them that HR is not an order taker only, but also a serious strategic player?

In this article, we will be focusing on the paradoxical roles of Human Resources, as it seems to be puzzling to a great extent, if not confusing.

Knowing the paradoxical truths about HR functions or roles cannot only revolutionize it, it can also give you a lot of wisdom and learning. The wisdom of paradoxes is that they transcend our thought system; they are in tune not just with logical intelligence, but also with existential wisdom that is at the roots of every deep and meaningful personal discovery.

Paradoxes can cause confusion, so the inquiry here is.



FROM EGYPT

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WHAT IS PARADOX?

People have long been fascinated by the idea of paradox. A circumstance or a statement that seems contradictory or ludicrous but has a hidden truth in it is called a paradox. There are contradictions in many different branches of human thought, including philosophy, mathematics, literature and management practices as well. A paradox is a statement or situation that appears to be contradictory or self-defeating but may contain a hidden truth or reveal a deeper complexity when examined more closely. Paradoxes often challenge our conventional thinking and can lead to thought-provoking insights.

THIS IS A PARADOX

A paradox is a self-contradictory statement.

"The sentence on the right is false."	"The sentence on the left is true."

In management, paradox refers to the challenges and contradictions that managers often face in their roles. These paradoxes arise from the complex and multifaceted nature of management, where managers must navigate competing demands and priorities. Here are some common management paradoxes:

- **CONTROL VS EMPOWERMENT:** Managers need to strike a balance between exerting control over their teams to ensure goals are met and empowering employees to make decisions and take ownership of their work;
- **SHORT-TERM VS LONG-TERM:** Managers often face pressure to deliver short-term results while also needing to plan for the long-term sustainability of their organization. Balancing immediate needs with long-term goals can be challenging;

- **STABILITY VS CHANGE:** Managers must maintain stability and continuity within their organizations while also driving change and innovation to adapt to a constantly evolving business environment;
- **INDIVIDUAL VS TEAM:** Managers need to recognize and reward individual contributions while fostering a sense of teamwork and collaboration within their teams.
- **RISK VS CAUTION:** Managers are often expected to take calculated risks to drive growth and innovation, but they must also exercise caution to minimize potential negative consequences;
- **AUTONOMY VS ALIGNMENT:** Balancing the autonomy of individual departments or teams with the need for alignment and coordination across the organization can be a delicate task;
- **COST EFFICIENCY VS QUALITY:** Managers must strive to reduce costs and improve efficiency while maintaining the quality of products or services, which can be a challenging trade-off;
- **LEADING VS MANAGING:** Effective managers must be both leaders who inspire and motivate their teams and managers who plan, organize, and control processes and resources;
- **GLOBAL VS LOCAL:** Managers in multinational organizations must consider the needs and practices of both global and local contexts, finding a balance between standardization and customization; and
- **INNOVATION VS STABILITY:** Encouraging innovation within an organization often involves disrupting existing systems and processes, which can conflict with the need for stability and consistency.

Paradoxes often come to the surface when there are external limitations on the access to financial, material, and human. We are using paradox as a general term to describe the tensions individuals face due to the coexistence of conflicting demands. Paradox has also been described as tensions, dilemmas, challenges, polarity, competing value and contradictions. No matter what you call them, they have in principles Yin-Yang, the Eastern Philosophy to understanding paradox.

Successfully navigating these management paradoxes requires adaptability, strategic thinking, effective communication, and a deep understanding of the organization's goals and culture. Skilled managers can embrace these paradoxes as opportunities for growth and find creative solutions that address both sides of each dilemma.



YIN AND YANG IN THE CHINESE CLASSICAL PHILOSOPHY ORIGINATES FROM TWO OF THE OLDEST BOOKS IN CHINA, *I CHING* (OR BOOK OF CHANGES) AND *TAO DE CHING*. THE PHILOSOPHY IS BASED ON THE PREMISE THAT ALL THINGS OR AGENTS IN THE WORLD CONSIST OF TWO OPPOSITE ELEMENTS THAT ARE PARTIALLY CONFLICTING AND PARTIALLY COMPLEMENTARY.

THE PARADOXES OF HR

Some of the comments to the questions were very convincing and practical, and here they are:

Ms. Enas Alatoom from Jordan stated that she believe that there are five major areas where these paradoxes can be highlighted:

- First is compliance with labor laws and regulations and organization's policies in front of fostering innovation culture among employees. The decision here is crucial to determine that the cost of innovation outweighs the cost of compliance despite compliance is cheaper. Second is standardization versus flexibility. While companies tend to standardize policies and procedures, they need to keep an open window to accommodate individual employee's needs and special circumstances. Third is cost control versus human and professional development for employees. Fourth and most challenging is balancing transparency versus confidentiality. At the time that HRMs need to keep transparency in organizational policies, they also need to tend to sensitive employee information. Fifth is advocacy for employees against advocacy for the organization.

Whereas, Ms Nashwa Nageeb from Egypt mentioned the following points: Enforcer and Advocate, Cost Manager and Value Creator, Compliance and Innovation, Employee Support and Business Partner, Risk Mitigation and Opportunity Seizing, Cost control and Employee Engagement. Other comments mentioned the same things, to great extent.

HR practitioners and employees can be paralyzed by conflicting demands and lose track of their tasks. In one hand, management is searching to hire very high calibre personnel (Top Notch), with good knowledge and experience, and on the other hand they say we do not pay high salaries.

Management demands to elevate performance and productivity of employees and train them on contemporary practices, and at the same time they then say to reduce or cut costs of training and development. I call such paradoxical truths "Pasteurization" for HR practitioners.

Human Resource Management (HRM) can sometimes appear paradoxical because it involves balancing various conflicting objectives and priorities within an organization. Some common HRM paradoxes include:

- **EMPLOYEE AUTONOMY VS CONTROL:** HRM needs to strike a balance between allowing employees autonomy in their work and maintaining necessary levels of control and oversight;
- **COST EFFICIENCY VS EMPLOYEE WELL-BEING:** Balancing cost-cutting measures with initiatives that support employee well-being and satisfaction can be challenging;
- **INDIVIDUAL VS ORGANIZATIONAL GOALS:** HRM must align individual employee goals with the broader objectives of the organization, which can sometimes be contradictory;
- **SHORT-TERM VS LONG-TERM FOCUS:** HRM often faces the challenge of addressing immediate personnel needs while also planning for the long-term development and sustainability of the workforce;
- **DIVERSITY AND INCLUSION VS CULTURAL FIT:** Striking a balance between promoting diversity and inclusion while also ensuring employees align with the organization's culture can be paradoxical;
- **STANDARDIZATION VS CUSTOMIZATION:** HRM must decide when to implement standardized HR policies and practices and when to tailor them to meet the unique needs of different employee groups; and
- **EMPLOYEE ADVOCACY VS ORGANIZATIONAL LOYALTY:** HR may need to advocate for employees' rights and well-being, even when it conflicts with the organization's interests.

Managing these paradoxes effectively is crucial for HR professionals to contribute positively to an organization's success. It requires a nuanced and strategic approach to HRM practices. ■

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